USO

BECOMING AMERICA'S NONPROFIT

IN 2026 AND BEYOND

THE STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

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- **Audience Strategy**
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  - — Growth & Giving
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BECOMING AMERICA'S NONPROFIT

Top 10 nonprofit in America

#1 nonprofit in the military & first-responder category

To reach this standard, the USO's mission must evolve for where the country — and culture — is today.

- Service delivery alone is no longer sufficient to sustain relevance or scale impact
- Inspiring and mobilizing the nation becomes core mission work, not a marketing function
- Visibility is not optional: Americans cannot support what they do not see or understand
- The USO must be positioned as America's nonprofit — a permanent part of the country's civic and cultural fabric, not simply a service provider

What that unlocks:

- Storytelling, content, and cultural engagement become program delivery, not overhead
- Donor dollars work harder — delivering service-member impact and national relevance
- The organization competes where attention is won today — consistently, credibly, and at scale

Who we serve, clearly:

- The USO exists to support the man or woman who volunteers to wear the uniform — and their families
- We represent the American people's support for those individuals, independent of politics or policy
- In a crowded veteran landscape, the USO is the nation's primary nonprofit for active-duty service members — where service and sacrifice are happening now

OUR MISSION

The USO strengthens the well-being of America's service members and their families throughout their time in uniform — and connects the nation to their service and sacrifice.

AUDIENCE STRATEGY – STARTING FROM REALITY

Visibility Comes Before Affinity — and Affinity Comes Before Giving

To reach that standard, we must be clear-eyed about where we are – so we can be intentional about where we're going.

The core challenge is not conversion.
The core challenge is visibility and affinity.

- Most Americans do not know who the USO is or what role it plays today
- Without visibility, there is no affinity
- Without affinity, there is no engagement or giving

Strategic implication:
Audience strategy must be sequenced – getting on the radar first, building connection next, and earning support over time.

This requires **intentional differentiation** – not one message, one channel, or one expectation across audiences.

GROWTH & GIVING

Where We Invest — and Why

If resources are finite, investment must be deliberate.

Primary conversion focus: Adults 40+, with heightened emphasis on 65+ audiences for near-term and legacy giving.

Paid media and direct-response efforts will be intentionally lopsided toward:

- Conservative audiences
- Faith-adjacent communities

Channels prioritized:

- Television and radio
- Digital platforms, including podcasts and streaming
- Faith- and values-aligned environments

Delivery principle:

- Messages will be delivered through trusted messengers and culturally familiar voices to ensure credibility, resonance, and trust

When year-round investment is not feasible:

- Efforts will be concentrated around patriotic and culturally relevant moments

Selective, high-impact bets:

- We will consider highest-value cultural touchpoints — including moments like a Super Bowl ad — when the opportunity justifies the investment

This is not exclusion. It is strategy.

Broad visibility builds relevance. Focused investment drives results.

PLANTING SEEDS

Long-Term Investment
Early and consistent exposure builds familiarity and civic connection before giving is the goal.

K–6 | Early Exposure
Goal: Familiarity and civic connection that compounds over time

Explore a K–6–focused early exposure model designed to:

- Introduce the USO mission in age-appropriate, values-driven ways
- Build positive association with service, sacrifice, and national gratitude
- Create early recognition that carries forward over time

Under 40 | Cultural Familiarity
Goal: Emotional connection and relevance — not conversion

- Reach this audience primarily through entertainment, storytelling, and cultural touchpoints
- Leverage talent, sports, brands, and platforms they already engage with
- Prioritize visibility, resonance, and values alignment over direct asks

We operate across all audiences simultaneously — with clear differentiation in goals, messaging, and investment by life stage.

EVOLVING ENTERTAINMENT

From Mission Delivery to Mission-Aligned Marketing

Entertainment is the USO's most powerful lever to establish and sustain cultural relevance. By aligning with trusted talent who already command national attention and credibility, we accelerate awareness, extend trust efficiently, and reach audiences at scale in ways few other capabilities allow.

To fully leverage this advantage, we will make the following shifts:

- **Extend impact beyond the installation**
  - Talent, ambassadors, and trusted voices authentically tell the USO story to their own audiences, multiplying reach beyond those physically present.
- **Increase cadence of high-impact, short-form stateside engagements**
  - Prioritize one-day and half-day experiences that are cost-efficient, repeatable, and capable of sustaining year-round relevance.
- **Shift from performance-first to presence-first engagement**
  - Move away from traditional performance tours (with comedy as the exception) in favor of access, authenticity, and meaningful interaction — meeting service members where they are, not asking them to show up.
- **Activate Ambassadors as subject-matter experts, not just participants**
  - Leverage their lived expertise and credibility to shape how the USO authentically engages the communities they influence.
- **Integrate into cultural crosspoints Americans already engage with**
  - Proactively pursue television, game shows, competitions, and brand or merchandise collaborations where attention and trust already exist.
- **Apply a higher bar to overseas tours**
  - Overseas engagements remain essential — but are reserved for the most thoughtfully designed, high-impact experiences and do not move forward unless the talent and story justify the investment.

PORTFOLIO ARCHITECTURE

SIGNATURE CULTURAL MOMEMNTS – *2-4 annually*

- Defining, once-in-a-lifetime service member experiences.
- Intentionally engineered for national storytelling resonance and lasting brand impact.

ENTERTAINMENT INTEGRATIONS – *4-6 annually*

- Celebrity beneficiary moments and competition show integrations.
- Entertainment-driven merchandise and product collaborations that drive revenue and reach.

STRATEGIC OVERSEAS ENGAGEMENTS – *6-8 annually*

- Deployed in response to elevated service member need.
- Advance only when mission impact, talent, and story justify the investment

STRATEGIC ENTRY (MVP) – *As opportunities arise*

- Short-form, low-lift engagements that open doors to talent and partners.
- Serve as relationship accelerators and pathways to deeper activation.

HIGH-CADENCE STATESIDE ENGAGEMENTS – *Primary volume*

- Half-day and one-day experiences delivered consistently throughout the year.
- Cost-efficient, repeatable, and designed for meaningful service member connection.

HOW INFLUENCE IS ENGINEERED

Every engagement is engineered through two lenses:

- What resonates most deeply with service members and military families
- Which public audience we are intentionally reaching

How influence is engineered:

- **Talent is evaluated by where their influence is anchored – and where it can lead**
  - Engagement architecture is intentionally designed for both on-base impact and outward reach
  - Projected narrative reach and downstream opportunity (media, partnerships, platforms) are considered alongside mission impact and budget
- **We embrace the modern reality of celebrity**
  - Shorter relevance cycles
  - Niche influence
  - Trusted voices that outperform scale
- **Storytelling is embedded, not incidental**
  - Content strategy is defined at planning, not after the fact
  - Story development adapts to the talent and audience
  - If a moment is worth creating, it is worth extending

Standard: We do not force engagements. If the talent, experience, or story does not justify the investment, it does not move forward.

SPORTS FOR SCALE

A Deliberate Focus Area — Not the Only One

Sports is the clearest opportunity for consistent, scalable national reach through trusted cultural platforms.

- Make sports a strategic priority, not one category among many
- Establish a repeatable cadence of franchise-connected engagements
- Structure engagements to be franchise-funded, with teams underwriting:
  - talent participation
  - travel and production
  - content capture and storytelling
  - experiential access for service members

Why Sports Works

- Sports franchises already command trust, loyalty, and civic pride within their communities.
- When teams tell the USO story to their audiences, it carries built-in credibility and patriotic alignment.

For franchises, alignment with the USO reinforces brand integrity, national pride, and community leadership – with minimal financial risk and high reputational return.

Net effect:
Expanded reach without increased donor cost – and a repeatable engine for relevance, awareness, and support.

TRANSITIONS – THE STRATEGIC QUESTION

Are We Investing in the Highest-Leverage Form of Transition Support?

- Transition services are widely available across military branches and the nonprofit sector.
- Much of today's transition support is transactional – and increasingly replicable through technology.
- Scaling our current model requires additional headcount in an already headcount-heavy program.

Key Questions:

- What does the USO deliver in Transitions that is truly proprietary – or demonstrably best-in-class?
- Where is our differentiated value, and is it visible in the experience we provide?
- Are we creating impact that justifies the organizational lift required to sustain and scale it?
- If resources are finite, are we allocating them to the most distinctive, high-return expression of our mission?

Strategic Tension:
Transition support matters – but the USO must deliver it in a way that is differentiated, scalable, and unmistakably aligned with our unique advantage.

TRANSITIONS REIMAGINED

From Transactional Services to Human Capital Transfer

Bringing exceptional lived experience, influence, and belief directly to service members.

- 1-2 hour base engagements with founders, CEOs, and respected thought leaders
- Focused on lived lessons: leadership, identity, resilience, risk, failure, and the choices that shape a life.
- Designed to reinforce service members' value and inspire them to imagine what comes next – in uniform or beyond it

Illustrative Participants: Jensen Huang (NVIDIA), Lynsi Snyder (In-N-Out), Michael Dell (Dell Technologies), Lisa Su (AMD), Steve Young (Investor; NFL Hall of Famer)

Why this approach delivers outsized value:

- Delivers transformational perspective that technology cannot replicate
- Requires minimal headcount to plan and execute, avoiding scaling drag
- Preserves eligibility for transition-focused grant funding
- **Establishes a pipeline to influential leaders and high-net worth individuals** – future donors, board members, corporate sponsors, and advocates **engaged through service, not solicitation**
- Creates opportunity for authentic amplification through trusted leaders whose audiences carry influence, trust, and capacity

Net Effect:
A distinctive, scalable transition model that equips service members perspective and confidence while expanding the USO's access to influential leaders, long-term capital, and trusted national reach.

THE OPPORTUNITY

This approach is not additive – it multiples value across every stakeholder.

For Service Members & Military Families

- More meaningful, human experiences that recognize service, sacrifice, and future potential
- Programs that honor the individual behind the uniform – not just the title or rank

For the Military

- Support that complements – rather than competes with – branch-led efforts
- A trusted philanthropic partner that tells the service member story through a non-political lens
- Increased public understanding, respect, and empathy toward those who serve
- A more united America that strengthens morale across the force

For the USO

- A mission model that integrates storytelling, visibility, and public engagement as program delivery – not overhead
- Stronger relevance, clearer narrative, and greater strategic flexibility
- Greater long-term sustainability in an increasingly competitive, attention-driven environment

For the American People & American Companies

- A credible and accessible way for Americans to express gratitude and connect to service through meaningful action
- A high-trust platform for companies to demomstrate values, deepen brand credibility, and engage customers

For the Country

- A unifying institution that connects Americans to service in a time of division
- A visible expression of shared responsibility and national purpose

Net Effect:
The USO becomes more than a service provider. It becomes American gratitude in action — strengthening service members and military families while uniting the nation around them.